2.5 million Japanese visited China, ranking second after South Korean tourists.

Yet the growing Sino-Japanese economic relationship has not been left unaffected by geopolitical tensions. Chinese protests against Japan over the Senkaku dispute led to steep declines in Japanese foreign direct investment in China during 2013 and 2014, with year-on-year investment dropping by 18 and 42 percent, respectively.[10] These declines were accompanied by a corresponding increase in Japanese investment in Southeast Asia, including Indonesia, Thailand, Malaysia, and Singapore.

Negative attitudes toward China on the part of Japanese business have been mirrored in the political and intellectual spheres. Japanese analysts have been concerned about the long-term implications of China's growth for years, but such concerns turned into open worry particularly after China's economy overtook Japan's in 2011. Since the crisis in political relations caused by repeated incidents in the Senkaku Islands starting in 2010, policy makers in Tokyo interpreted Beijing's actions as flexing newfound national muscle, and they grew frustrated with the United States for its seemingly cavalier attitude toward Chinese assertiveness in the East China Sea. At one international conference in 2016, a senior Japanese diplomat harshly criticized Washington and other Asian capitals for countering China's expansion in Asian waters with nothing but rhetoric and warned that it might soon be too late to blunt Beijing's attempts to gain military dominance. "You don't get it," he repeated in unusually blunt language, decrying what he (and perhaps his superiors) saw as undue complacency about China's encroachment throughout Asia. It is not difficult to get the sense that China is seen by some leading thinkers and officials as a near-existential threat to Japan's freedom of action.

As for Chinese officials, they are all but dismissive of Japan and its future prospects. One leading academic claimed in private conversation that China already has more wealthy citizens than the entire population of Japan, so that there could be no competition between the two; Japan simply can't keep up, he asserted, so its influence (and